SPARTA GLOBAL | AI & TECH INSTITUTE

AI FUNDAMENTALS

AGENTIC AI:
FROM INSTRUCTIONS TO INTENT

Understand how agentic AI has evolved to work autonomously, and what that changes about oversight, trust, and control

LAST SESSION

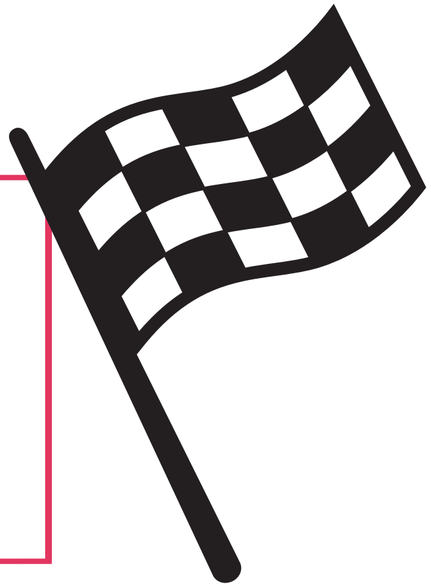
AI FOR AUTOMATION

Identify opportunities for workflow automation, design AI-powered processes, and implement appropriate human oversight and safeguards

TODAY

AGENTIC AI

Understand how agentic AI evolved to sets its own steps toward a goal, and what that changes about oversight, trust and control



SESSION OVERVIEW

01 **The Evolution of Enterprise AI**

02 **How AI Agents Work**

03 **Agents in Practice**

04 **Responsible Agency**

LEARNING OBJECTIVES



- → Describe how enterprise AI has evolved
- → Understand how agents can be applied to a task
- → Explain how AI agents plan, and act towards their goal
- → Assess the real cost of agentic delegation

01

The Evolution of Enterprise AI

Assistance to Collaboration to Delegation

THE EVOLUTION OF (ENTERPRISE) AI

THE 5 LEVELS OF AI USE

MANUAL

WHO DECIDES

You do the work

No flow at all

ASSISTANCE

WHO DECIDES

- You run each step
- AI drafts
- You accept or reject

Copilot writing in a document

COLLABORATION

WHO DECIDES

- The flow runs itself
- AI decides one defined step

Popular LLM Usage

DELEGATION

WHO DECIDES

- You set a goal
- The model chooses the:
  - Steps
  - Order
  - Tools

Today's Session

LESS INSTRUCTION, MORE INTENT — AND LESS ABILITY TO PREDICT WHAT WILL ACTUALLY HAPPEN

THE EVOLUTION OF (ENTERPRISE) AI

REFLECTION

QUESTION

What's the level of AI use you are currently using?

Most people are still using AI solely as an Assistant

QUESTION

Is a higher level always better?

THE EVOLUTION OF ENTERPRISE AI

THREE WAVES

Systems that Record Work

ERP, CRM, Ticketing

The system holds the data

People do the thinking

Tools that Assist Work

Search, Autocomplete, Copilots

The tool suggests

People decide

Agents that do Work

Claude, Codex, Jules

The system holds a goal, chooses its own steps, and reports a result

THE EVOLUTION OF ENTERPRISE AI

AI AGENTS

An **AI agent** is a system that can pursue a goal, decide what to do next, take actions using tools, and adapt based on what happens

- Agents have *agency*, they can make decisions on our behalf in pursuit of a goal
- Once given a goal, it creates a plan, actions the plan, and adapts if neccessary
- Humans are still involved:
  - Approving the plan
    - *It reasons, you see the plan before anything runs*
  - Gating Actions
    - *It proposes a call, you allow or refuse it*
  - Stopping
    - *You interrupt, redirect, or cap how long it keeps going*

THE EVOLUTION OF ENTERPRISE AI

FOUR CAPABILITY QUESTIONS FOR ANY TOOL

GOAL

Does it hold a goal across multiple steps, or only answer the turn in front of it?

TOOLS

Can it use tools to change the state of the world, or only produce text?

SEQUENCE

Does it decide the sequence itself, or follow a path someone else wrote?

SELF-CHECK

Does it check its own work against a result, and retry when it is wrong?

Four yeses is an agent. Anything less is a tool with a model in it.

THE EVOLUTION OF ENTERPRISE AI

IS IT AGENTIC?

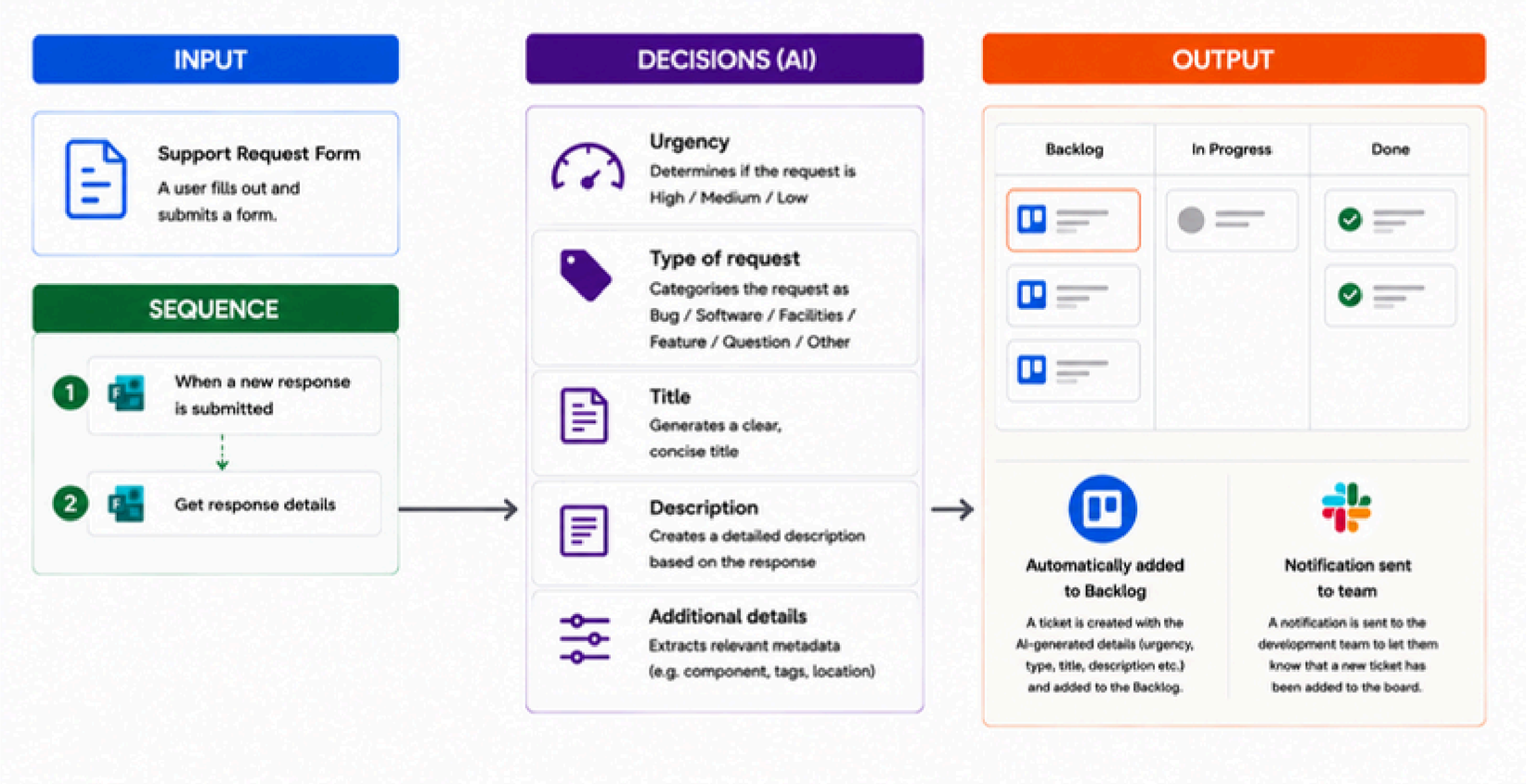
TOOL	GOAL	TOOLS	SEQUENCE	SELF-CHECK
Teams Copilot meeting summary	No	No	No	No
GitHub Copilot inline suggestions	No	No	No	No
GitHub Copilot code review	Partly	Yes	No	Partly
Claude Code	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

QUESTION

Which of the above are agents?

THE EVOLUTION OF ENTERPRISE AI

SESSION 4 REFLECTION



QUESTION

Is our Session 4 Flow an Agent?

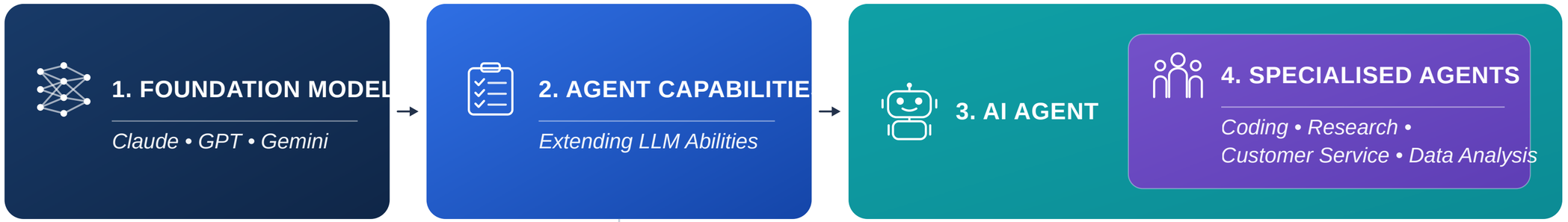
02

How AI Agents Work

Plan, Act, Iterate

HOW AI AGENTS WORK

ANATOMY OF AN AI AGENT



WHAT'S INSIDE STEP 2

INSTRUCTIONS

Goal & task definition guide the agent.

TOOLS

APIs, files, databases, code, applications and more.

MEMORY / CONTEXT

Relevant information and past interactions the agent can use.

AGENT LOGIC

Rules, strategies and decision frameworks for behaviour.

HOW AI AGENTS WORK

AGENT LOGIC LOOP



- The plan is generated, not given - it is a guess, sometimes the wrong one
- Iterations is the part a workflow cannot do: if it fails, it notices, and changes approach
- What it did and what it claims it proved are two different things

HOW AI AGENTS WORK

WHAT AN AGENT NEEDS

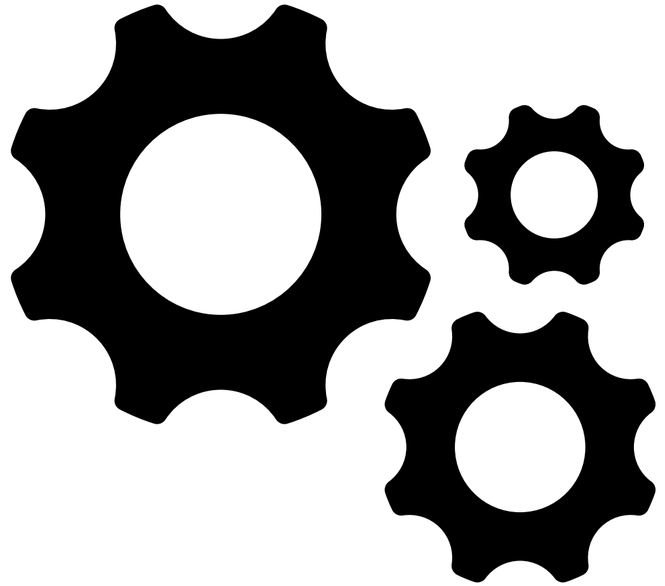
01	**MISSION**	What outcome are we trying to achieve?
02	**CONTEXT**	What organisational or task information does it need?
03	**TOOLS**	What systems and capabilities does it need?
04	**PERMISSIONS**	What is it allowed to access and do?
05	**INSTRUCTIONS / SKILLS**	What rules or ways of working should guide it?

LLM Intelligence alone is not enough.

HOW AI AGENTS WORK

TOOL USE

- **Tools extend what an LLM can do**
  - Allowing an agent to retrieve information, interact with software and take actions rather than only generate text
- **Each tool provides a specific capability**
  - E.g. searching the web, querying a database, read a file, or interact with an app
- **The agent decides when to use the available tools based on its goal**
  - Judges this based on its goal and the output information



N.B. You may hear MCP, connectors, plugins, skills or extensions - all different mechanisms for giving AI access to external capabilities

QUESTION

Have we come across this concept before?

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

PROMINENT LLM: CLAUDE

- A member of Anthropic's LLM family
- Long-context reasoning: works across large information sets and sustains multi-step tasks
- Built for reliable agentic behaviour - tool use, planning, and performance over long-running tasks
- Runs inside Excel, Chrome and the terminal
    - *Agents work where teams already work*



AGENTS IN PRACTICE

PROMINENT LLM: GPT

- GPT is OpenAI’s family of large language models, powering ChatGPT and a broad range of applications built through OpenAI's platform
- Strong focus on multimodal intelligence - working across text, images, audio and other inputs, alongside advanced reasoning
- OpenAI has built a broad agent ecosystem around GPT, enabling models to use web search, files, external functions and computer interfaces to complete tasks



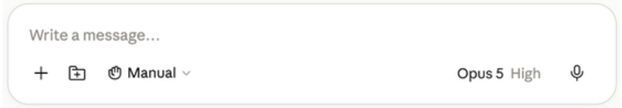
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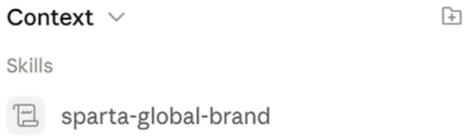
Agents in Practice

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

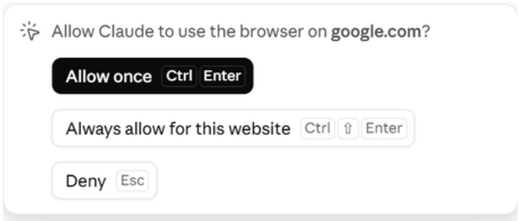
CLAUDE

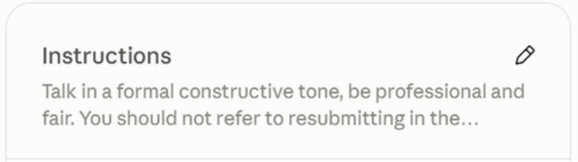
01	**MISSION**	You tell it
02	**CONTEXT**	You give it
03	**TOOLS**	Looks through its toolkit
04	**PERMISSIONS**	Stop and Ask
05	**INSTRUCTIONS / SKILLS**	You give it and/or it obtains from context





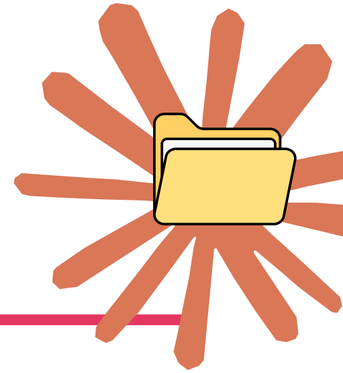






AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CLAUDE: DEMO



DEMO

General Agentic Knowledge Work

MISSION

"Prepare me for tomorrow's project meeting on project ATI. Find the latest project information, identify recent decisions, summarise outstanding actions, check relevant discussions and produce a one-page briefing."

WHAT I AM DOING

- Giving a goal, not a list of sources
- Letting it choose what to look at
- Narrating Mission, Context, Tools and Permissions as they appear

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

- Multiple decisions and tool calls between my instruction and the result
- Where it changes course after seeing what came back
- Any moment it has to ask permission

5-mins

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CLAUDE FOR EXCEL: DEMO



DEMO

Agentic Integrations

MISSION

"Update the attendance tracker with the latest ATI meeting's attendance. Preserve the existing structure and formulas. Create a new column for average attendance rates and flag anyone below 80%."

THE CONTEXT IT NEEDS

- The master workbook and its structure
- The existing formulas it must not break
- The 80% threshold and what it means
- A new, messy attendance export

THEN PUSH IT FURTHER

- "Explain why these people were flagged"
- "Create a summary for the training manager"
- Watch where it has to make a judgement — matching messy names to existing rows

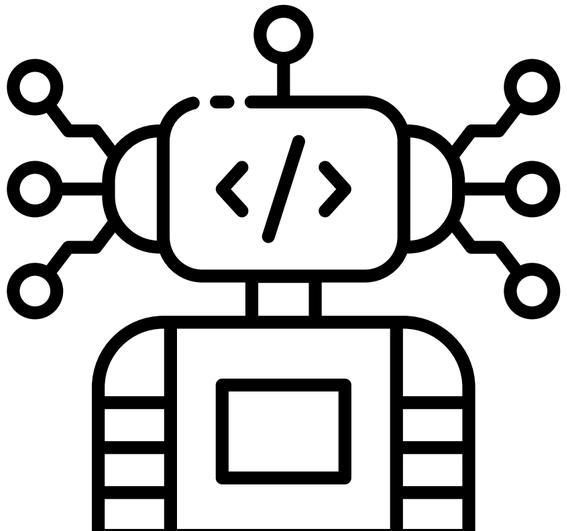
10-mins

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CODING AGENTS

A **coding agent** is a specialised type of AI agent whose environment is a codebase, whose tools are a developer's, and which can run what it produces - so the environment, not the human, tells it whether it worked.

- Examples of popular coding agents:
  - Claude Code
  - GitHub Copilot
  - Cursor
  - Gemini CLI



AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CODING AGENTS VS GENERIC AI AGENT

TYPICAL AI AGENT

Goal → **Reason** → **Act with tools** → **Observe** → **Adjust** → **Repeat**

What comes back: a search result, a document, a reply. Useful — but nothing in it says “you got this wrong”.

CODING AGENT

1. Understand codebase	**2. Plan** changes	**3. Edit** files / code	**4. Run** software
5. Test behaviour	**6. Observe** errors / logs	**7. Debug** refine	**8. Deliver** a passing change

Execution feedback loop: run → observe → adjust → repeat

What comes back: a stack trace, a failed assertion, a non-zero exit code. The environment states, unambiguously, that it is wrong.

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CODING AGENTS VS GENERIC AI AGENT

The environment answers back

A compiler, a test suite and a runtime give an objective verdict in seconds.

Most knowledge work has no equivalent — nothing tells a briefing that it is wrong.

It can run its own output

You cannot execute a summary or a strategy.

Code can be run, so the agent catches many of its own failures before you see them.

The work is diffable and revertible

Version control makes every change visible, reviewable and undoable.

Few other outputs come with that safety net built in.

The tools are execute-level

A terminal can do anything you can do on that machine.

A far wider blast radius than search, a connector or a document tool.

It got good first because it could check itself — and it needs the tightest guardrails for the same reason.

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

VIBE CODING

Vibe coding is where you build software primarily by expressing the outcome in natural language, and let AI handle much of the implementation

- It lowers the barrier to prototyping dramatically
- But as the human moves further from the implementation, understanding and verification fall behind
  - The code still exists. The knowledge of what it does may not
- If you didn’t write the code, how do you know if it is correct?

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

CLAUDE CODE: DEMO

DEMO

Agentic Development

MISSION

"Change the code from Session 2 to run multiple times and generate a html report showing how temperature affects outputs, and how repeatability shows the effects. Have a summary at the end describing findings and when and where temperature adjustments are appropriate."

THE LIVE LOOP

CREATE ▶ RUN ▶ OBSERVE ▶ FIX ▶ REPEAT

Think: Mission · Context · Tools · Permissions · Instructions

10-mins

AGENTS IN PRACTICE

WHY?

	CLAUDE	CLAUDE CODE	CLAUDE FOR EXCEL
MISSION	Prepare me for a meeting	Build a dashboard	Update the tracker
CONTEXT	Project information and discussions	Repository, config, tests	Workbook, formulas, threshold
TOOLS	Search, connectors, browser	Filesystem, terminal, runtime	Workbook and calculation engine
PERMISSIONS	Mostly read	Read, modify and execute	Read and modify
WHERE IT DECIDED	Which sources were worth checking	Which files to change, how to fix a failure	How to match messy names to rows
AGENT LOOP	Reason · act · observe · adjust	Reason · act · observe · adjust	Reason · act · observe · adjust

The interface changed. The agent pattern did not.

04

Responsible Agency

Balancing autonomy with accountability

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

THE ISSUE WITH AGENTIC AUTONOMY

CHATBOT

BAD REASONING ▶ BAD ANSWER ▶ A HUMAN SEES IT BEFORE ANYTHING HAPPENS

AGENT

BAD REASONING ▶ ACTION TAKEN ▶ REAL-WORLD CONSEQUENCE

- It is no longer only “could the AI be wrong?”
- It is **“what happens if it is wrong, and it can act?”**

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

THE BLAST RADIUS OF ACCESS

READ	Retrieve, search, analyse
CREATE	Draft, prepare, generate
MODIFY	Edit files, records, spreadsheets, code
EXECUTE	Send, delete, publish, deploy, transact

Claude demo: mostly read. · *Excel: modification.* · *Claude Code: read, modify and execute.*

Same intelligence, different consequences. The wider the toolset and permissions, the larger the blast radius of a wrong plan.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

LEAST PRIVILEGE

SCOPE

What can it access?

Which files, which systems, which records — and which it has no reason to see at all.

ACTION

What can it do there?

Read only, or create, modify and execute. Access and permission are two different questions.

DURATION

How long does it need it?

For this task, this session, or permanently? Standing access is the easiest thing to forget.

An agent should have the access required for its mission - not all of the access its user happens to have.

An agent inherits the permissions of whoever set it up. That is convenient, and it is the problem.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

REVERSIBILITY

EASIER TO REVERSE

- A draft
- An analysis
- A local file
- A proposed change, not yet applied

HARDER TO REVERSE

- An external communication
- A deleted record
- Code merged to production
- Published content, or a financial transaction

Reversibility decides how much friction, approval and validation should stay in the way.

The harder it is to undo, the less of the loop the agent should own.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

VIBE CODING

RESPONSIBLE AGENTIC DEVELOPMENT

DEFINE THE OUTCOME ▶ AGENT IMPLEMENTS ▶ YOU STAY ENGAGED ▶ REVIEW · TEST · UNDERSTAND ▶ YOU OWN THE RESULT

THE VIBE CODING FAILURE MODE

"BUILD THIS" ▶ AGENT IMPLEMENTS ▶ SEEMS TO WORK ▶ SHIP IT

Using an AI coding agent is not the problem. Treating code you do not understand, have not reviewed and cannot verify as trustworthy is.

DELEGATE THE WORK. DON'T DELEGATE OWNERSHIP OF THE WORK.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

SPARTA'S POSITION ON VIBE CODING

DO NOT VIBE CODE

Not on client work. Not on assessments. Not on anything with your name on it.

OWN THE WORK

You are the author of everything you submit, whoever or whatever typed it.

KNOW WHAT IS HAPPENING

Read every change. Be able to explain every line without the AI in the room.

Use the agent to move faster through work you understand, and never to skip understanding it.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

THE CLIENT TEST

IF THIS REACHES A CLIENT TOMORROW AND SOMETHING BREAKS, CAN YOU EXPLAIN WHAT IT DOES — ON YOUR OWN, WITH THE TOOL CLOSED?

FOUR SITUATIONS — WHICH PASS?

I read every change and can explain each one	**PASSES**	You delegated.
It passed the tests, so I shipped it	**FAILS**	Tests check what someone thought to test.
I approved the plan and skimmed the diff	**USUALLY FAILS**	Would you have spotted the bug?
It's a throwaway I am deleting today	**DOES NOT APPLY**	But say so out loud — and actually delete it.

The problem is never the speed. It is the unread output reaching someone who trusts you.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

MAKE MISTAKES CHEAP

SANDBOX

Experiment safely.

Test or synthetic data, restricted permissions, no production impact.

TEST

Validate before it matters.

Outputs, edge cases, actions and integrations.

PRODUCTION

Real systems, real data, real consequences.

Stronger controls, narrower permissions.

Don't discover what an agent can do for the first time in an environment where mistakes matter.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

VERIFICATION

An agent saying “done” or “everything looks correct” is a claim, not independent evidence.

WHAT VERIFICATION ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

RECONCILIATION
Totals and counts against the source

TESTS
Automated checks that fail loudly

SOURCE COMPARISON
The output against the original data

BUSINESS RULES
Satisfies the rule, not just looks right

EXCEPTION REPORTS
Surface the odd cases for a person

HUMAN REVIEW
Proportionate to the blast radius

Verification tests the outcome. Asking the same agent whether it succeeded tests nothing.

RESPONSIBLE AGENCY

5 QUESTIONS

01	**ACCESS**	What can it see?
02	**ACTION**	What can it change or execute?
03	**BLAST RADIUS**	What is the worst plausible consequence of a mistake?
04	**REVERSIBILITY**	Can we undo what it does?
05	**VERIFICATION**	How will we independently know that it worked?

AGENTIC AI

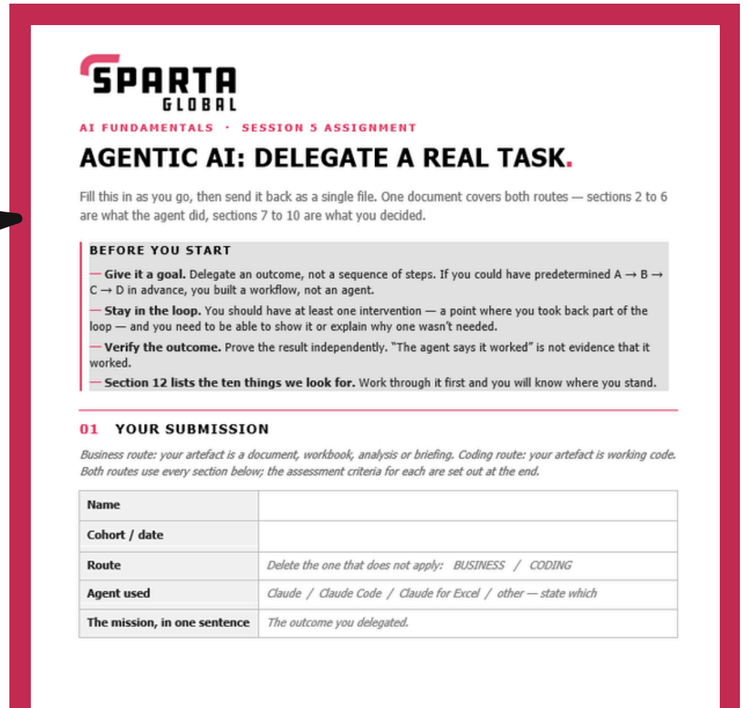
THE FINAL ASSIGNMENT

Complete a realistic task by delegating it to an AI agent

You can choose a business scenario or a coding scenario

Submission document to fill out

- *Your starting point, and why it needed an agent*
- *Your prompt, and how you set the agent up*
- *The agent's plan, and where it adjusted*
- *A recording, with your intervention marked*
- *The artefact, and how you verified it*
- *The five questions, answered*
- *Ownership, cost and risk*



SPARTA GLOBAL

AI FUNDAMENTALS · SESSION 5 ASSIGNMENT

AGENTIC AI: DELEGATE A REAL TASK.

Fill this in as you go, then send it back as a single file. One document covers both routes — sections 2 to 6 are what the agent did, sections 7 to 10 are what you decided.

BEFORE YOU START

— **Give it a goal.** Delegate an outcome, not a sequence of steps. If you could have predetermined A → B → C → D in advance, you built a workflow, not an agent.

— **Stay in the loop.** You should have at least one intervention — a point where you took back part of the loop — and you need to be able to show it or explain why one wasn't needed.

— **Verify the outcome.** Prove the result independently. "The agent says it worked" is not evidence that it worked.

— **Section 12 lists the ten things we look for.** Work through it first and you will know where you stand.

01 YOUR SUBMISSION

Business route: your artefact is a document, workbook, analysis or briefing. Coding route: your artefact is working code. Both routes use every section below; the assessment criteria for each are set out at the end.

Name	
Cohort / date	
Route	*Delete the one that does not apply: BUSINESS / CODING*
Agent used	*Claude / Claude Code / Claude for Excel / other — state which*
The mission, in one sentence	*The outcome you delegated.*

SESSION OUTCOMES

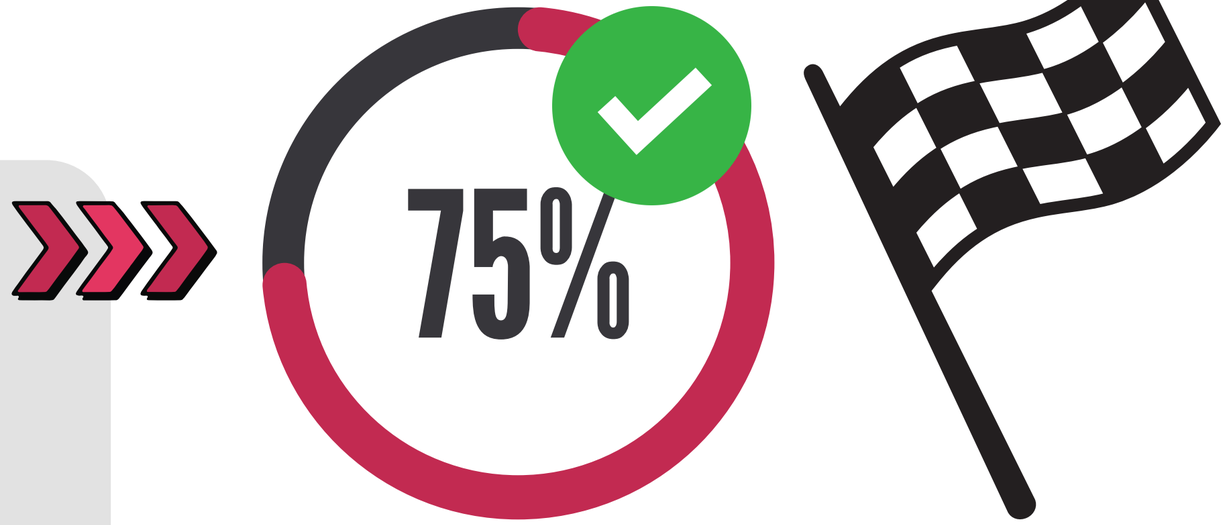
OBJECTIVES ACHIEVED

- Describe how enterprise AI has evolved
- Understand how agents can be applied to a task
- Explain how AI agents plan, and act towards their goal
- Assess the real cost of agentic delegation

SESSION OUTCOMES

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THANK YOU